seeing so many young, dynamic and ideologically sharp people during the Yatra. The easy mingling of young and old added to the sense of togetherness. The yatris felt a sense of special belonging that I hope will be rewarded in myriad ways of involvement and recognition.

I think this unique ideological and programmatic formulation of the Yatra was largely because of Rahul. He has always wanted to walk the path less taken, which is why he keeps experimenting with innovative methods to connect deeper with the people, whether it be travelling in truck cabins, spending time with railway coolies, lending a hand to motor mechanics or just enjoying a meal in a small dhaba. Democracy is about being connected. And Rahul tried very hard to remain connected to ordinary citizens so he could share their dreams, aspirations, concerns and fears. In this light, Rudyard Kipling comes to mind:

> If you can walk with the crowd and keep your virtue, or walk with Kings-nor lose the common touch; If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you; If all men count with you, but none too much; If you can fill the unforgiving minute with 60 seconds worth of distance run-Yours is the earth and everything that's in it, And-which is more-you'll be a man my son.

Then and now, the Yatra is a symbol of hope. On the one hand, it gives hope to those who are desperate for a Nehruvian India. But it also became a symbol of hope for the Congress party. It has allowed the party to reoccupy the political landscape in some measure. And it gave us an opportunity to hear the wisdom of our people. Many of the learnings from Kanyakumari to Kashmir were methodically included in the various declarations of the Congress party's Raipur session. Respect and consideration for the majority without marginalizing the minorities is the top challenge of current-day politics. Balancing affirmative action for the vulnerable and disadvantaged with meritocracy is another. Using identity for social justice without causing deep divides between communities is a burning issue that cannot be ignored. Ultimately, providing a link or bridge between the modern and the